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Asking Questions Using Conversations

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Asking Questions Using Conversations

Every day we have conversations about things such as sports, hobbies, health, diets, politics, finances, weather, shopping, family, children, pets—you name it.

I recently was at the airport, and standing next to me was a man in a suit who looked like he worked there. I asked him if he worked at the airport, and he told me he was a limousine driver. I asked him where he was from. He said Uzbekistan, and I asked, “What is the religion of Uzbekistan?” He said about 90 percent are Muslims, and about 10 percent are Russian Orthodox. It turned out that he was an agnostic. I shared the gospel with him and told him, “Of all the great religious leaders, Jesus is the only who declared He was God and that He would rise from the dead exactly three days after His crucifixion. Mohammed, Buddha, and Confucius are still in the grave, but Jesus’s tomb is empty. I’ve been in Christ’s tomb, and it’s empty.” He then asked, “Dave, did it take you three days to get out?” We laughed, and then I told him about Y-Jesus.com and that it has scholarly articles and videos such as “[Did Jesus Rise from the Dead?](#)” “[Is Jesus God?](#)” and many other related topics. He asked me if he could take a picture of my phone that showed the website Y-Jesus.com. My prayer is that he will find Jesus someday from this website. Asking questions shows a genuine interest and helps you understand people’s fears, hurts, concerns, and needs in life.

Be a Good Listener

James wrote, “Be quick to hear, slow to speak” (James 1:19). People are more inclined to listen to us and share our beliefs if we listen to them. Lee Strobel said, “Many times the best gift we can give our spiritually seeking friends is our time, a listening ear, and a caring heart.”

A recent Barna study states, “People of no faith are clear that they are looking for understanding, empathy, and belonging.” Some gospel presentations are like a sermon or a script that allows for little interaction with the person you are sharing Christ with. Let them talk, and consider asking when you do share, “Does this make sense to you?” or “What do you think?”

Expect people to throw out questions, but don't be afraid to ask them questions in return. By asking questions, they may realize that their worldview is not based on rational arguments. Jesus was a master at asking questions. He would often ask them a question in return.

In Randy Newman's book *Questioning Evangelism* is a chapter called "Why Are Questions Better Than Answers?" Newman said, "It's uncanny how often our Lord answered a question with a question." Newman encourages the use of questions more than direct answers. In fact, Jesus used a mix of probing and rhetorical questions when talking to people. When people questioned his authority, Jesus said, "I will ask you a question, and you tell Me; Was the baptism of John from heaven or from men?" (Luke 20:3-4).

Informational Questions

"Who do people say I am?" (Mark 8:27, 29 NIV). "Who do you say I am?" Jesus asked the Samaritan woman at the well. "Will you give me a drink?" (John 4:7 NIV). He then spoke to her about salvation.

Discerning Questions

"And [Jesus] asked them, 'How many loaves do you have?' They said, 'Seven'" (Mark 8:5). We may ask in a given situation, "What do you think?"

Corresponding Questions

"[Jesus] answered them, 'What did Moses command you?'" (Mark 10:3). Jesus said, "What is written in the law? How do you read it?" (Luke 10:26 ESV). You can ask a person to read a scripture such as Romans 6:23, Ephesians 2:8-9, or Revelation 3:20. Then ask them what they think it means. Bill Fay in *Share Jesus without Fear* asks the person to read the scripture aloud and then asks them, "What does this say or mean to you?"

Conversational Questions

1. Do you have any kind of spiritual belief? At what point are you in your spiritual journey in life? Do you go to church anywhere?
2. When you and I leave this planet, what do you think is on the other side?

3. Do you believe that God exists and that you can know Him personally?
4. Do you consider yourself a good person?
5. What role, if any, has God ever played in your life?
6. Do you ever wonder about life after death?

Questions Relating to Heaven

- On a scale of 1 to 100, how would you rate your certainty of going to heaven?
 - What do you think are the general entrance requirements into heaven?
 - If you were to die tonight, how sure are you that you would go to heaven?
 - If you were to die tonight and God were to ask you, “Why should I let you into heaven?” what would you say to God?
7. Has anyone ever taken the time to explain how a personal relationship with God is possible?

Below are some questions to ask when people go through trials (from Randy Newman’s *Questioning Evangelism*):

1. What have you found helpful in handling such difficult things?
2. Do you have the kind of faith that has helped you deal with this?
3. Would you mind if I prayed with you right now?

Bill Fay’s book *Share Jesus without Fear* has five main questions he asks people to open up a conversation on spiritual matters.

1. Do you have any kind of spiritual belief? Do you ever think about spiritual things?
2. To you, who is Jesus Christ?
3. Do you think that there is a heaven or a hell? Do you ever ponder about life after death?
4. If you died, where would you go? If you say heaven, why would God let you in?
5. If what you believe is not true, would you want to know?

Emotional Questions

I’m sure you’ve had people ask you, “How’s your day going?” As you get to know people and show them that you care, sometimes they will open up and share what they’re going through.

We live in a culture where everyone is tied to their mobile devices and people are lonely and socially starved. The next time you are at a doctor's office, at the airport, or in a restaurant, watch how many people are tied to their cell phones. Listening shows that you care. It allows you to understand more where they're coming from and can be an entryway to the gospel.

Application: Write down 5-7 questions on a 3" x 5" card or in the box below so you can review it for a gospel conversation starter.

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